

AKHILESH YADAV IS OVER AN HOUR LATE for his drive-through election rally in Hazratganj, Lucknow's main shopping centre, and yet instead of dissipating, the crowd only grows in a strange, primal fashion—the way you may see a forest growing in a time-lapse video—till it becomes that surging organismic mass that greets his campaign bus. There is an adulation, the kind only rockstars get, as women wave to catch his attention and bands of young men reach out desperately to touch his hand. Some of the more energetic ones perform dangerous acrobatics, with pillion riders standing up on moving motorcycles, waving flags at him while taking selfies. There are those who want to present him with large bronze maces, others with shiny photos of Hindu gods or fancy tiny models of cycles (his party's symbol) or floral garlands. As Akhilesh spots each offering in the crowd, he tells his driver to stop and reaches out to collect it... even though his arms are in danger of being pulled out of their sockets. "The least I can do is to receive their gifts—it keeps me connected to them and the memory will always stay with them," Akhilesh remarks. He speaks in his characteristic style, disarming and free of bombast, but everybody here in this multitude will be hoping that something more than mere memory stays with them.

Similar crowds thronged the route his campaign bus took through the city. Just two days later, on February 23, Lucknow voted—part of a swathe of central Uttar Pradesh, 59 constituencies in all, bunched together for the fourth phase of the assembly election. Lucknow city is considered a Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) pocket borough. It has won the lone Lok Sabha seat here eight consecutive times since 1991, and swept all its five constituent assembly seats in 2017. Can the visible surge of support for Akhilesh here be a sign that there is a wave in favour of the Samajwadi Party (SP) leader across the state? Akhilesh, for one, refuses to get bowled over by the crowds, saying, "It's energising to experience, but I still have a long distance to go." True enough. There are three more phases left, that too in the complex playfield of eastern UP. So that honest acknowledgement shows just how rooted the SP leader is as he gets down with his team to fine-tune the party's campaign strategy for the rest of the battle.

It would be a political miracle if the 48-year-old Akhilesh were to pull off a win. (The results are due on March 10). In 2017, the BJP had polled nearly 40 per cent of the votes and won a massive majority of 312 of the 403 seats on its own (the NDA won 325 in all). In contrast, the SP, which had won a majority of 224 seats in 2012 with a vote share of 29 per cent, got a sound thrashing in 2017. Its seat tally dropped to an ignominious 47—its lowest since its inception in 1992—and its vote share fell to 21.8 per cent. If Akhilesh has to beat the BJP, he must not only ensure that the SP's vote share doubles to around 40 per cent, but do that by making a significant dent in the BJP's vote share. Such a numerical reversal is by itself not an impossible task—the BJP did something similar in 2017, turbo-charging itself to go from 15 per cent to an astounding 39.7 per cent of overall votes. The question is whether Akhilesh has created anything matching in terms of a positive *lehar* (wave). Or, even if that falls short as a singular propulsive factor, does a negative anti-incumbency tendency exist that's strong enough to make up for the deficit?

The answer to that question remains in the balance, but many psephologists acknowledge that what Akhilesh has achieved so far is already remarkable. In a crowded field, he has succeeded in positioning himself